

Report 1

BENGALURU'S BUSIEST BUS HUB FAILS ITS SPECIALLY-ABLED COMMUTERS BY- NABONITA BANERJEE 2530146 2BAJE

Kempegowda Bus Station, commonly known as Majestic, is one of Bengaluru's busiest public transport hubs, handling lakhs of commuters every day. It plays a central role in connecting different parts of the city and neighbouring regions. Yet, despite its size and importance, the station continues to fall short in one key area: accessibility for people with disabilities. A walk around Majestic shows that many basic commuter facilities are in place, including parking areas, seating, toilets, shops, and ATMs. However, the infrastructure remains largely unsupportive of commuters with disabilities. Apart from two ramps near the washrooms, there is little in the way of functional accessibility. There are no tactile paths for visually impaired users, no clearly marked wheelchair-friendly boarding points, and lifts on key platforms are either missing or not in working condition. For a station of such importance, this isn't just an oversight — it's a symptom of how inclusivity often gets left behind in urban design. "Accessibility cannot be treated as an extra feature. It's a basic requirement," said Sunitha Rao, a disability-rights volunteer. "When a major hub like Majestic fails to provide it, it sends the message that people with disabilities are an afterthought." The struggle becomes even more visible during rush hours. As crowds squeeze through the narrow passages and navigate the uneven flooring, even regular commuters struggle to move with ease. For people with mobility impairments, negotiating the same space becomes extremely difficult, if not impossible. Outside the station, wheelchair user Ravish Bhog shared his experience: "I always need someone to help me move through the crowds or get into a bus. I want to be independent when I travel, not constantly depend on others." His words capture how poor infrastructure chips away at personal dignity and self-reliance. A Deccan Herald report titled "City's Big Bus Stations Disabled-Unfriendly" notes that many major BMTC bus stations still lack basic accessibility features such as tactile flooring, functioning lifts, and clearly marked boarding areas for people with disabilities. The absence of these facilities not only restricts independent movement but also goes against the spirit of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016, which calls for public spaces to be made accessible. Experts in urban mobility point out that when infrastructure is designed with the most vulnerable users in mind, it ends up improving safety and ease of use for everyone, not just people with disabilities. They stress that accessibility measures should be viewed as essential public investments rather than optional add-ons. At Majestic, recent modernisation has added more shops, stalls, and ATMs, increasing convenience for many commuters but also adding to congestion in already crowded areas. For people with disabilities, particularly those using wheelchairs or walking aids, moving through these busy, cluttered corridors can become especially challenging. Clear signage and guided pathways — essential for visually impaired users — remain largely absent. BMTC officials admit that accessibility improvements are overdue but cite "infrastructural challenges" and "phased renovation plans." One senior official said, "We are aware that accessibility upgrades are needed." Officials say that expanding the station's capacity while also making it fully accessible is a complicated task, and claim that upgrade plans are underway. However, without clear timelines or any public accountability, these promises risk sounding like routine bureaucratic statements rather than firm commitments. Urban planners and disability-rights groups recommend a phased, practical

plan to make Majestic more inclusive. This would include ramps at all entry and exit points, functional lifts, tactile pathways, accessible ticket counters, and clearly marked boarding areas for wheelchair users, along with regular audits by independent disability-rights organisations to track progress. Bengaluru often presents itself as a modern, technology-driven city, but its growth is ultimately judged by how it treats its most vulnerable residents. As the city's central transport hub, Majestic has the opportunity to set a benchmark for accessible public infrastructure, if these changes are planned and implemented in earnest. Until that happens, many commuters will continue to be left on the margins, excluded not by choice, but by design.

REFLECTIVE ESSAY

Doing this article, not only helped me in my course related assignment, but also gave me a chance to travel around Bengaluru. This assignment made me realise how much paying attention to small details can be helpful. Problems that might seem minute to some could be the most major problems for others. I had never realised how difficult it could be for specially-abled people to transit by bus as I had never faced that myself. Talking to the disabled people turned out to be extremely insightful and motivating. While travelling by bus, I always felt that the space to walk in Majestic station was very compact, but I had never realised how difficult it could be for the specially-abled people to commute day-to-day. This assignment not only gave me a better look inside Bengaluru's urban planning but also gave an insight on how people who are in the minority population could be overlooked. It also taught me to pay attention to minor details and workings behind the minute things.

Report 2

Agara Lake Water Crisis Sparks Major Health Concerns in HSR Layout BY- NABONITA BANERJEE 2530146 2BAJE

On inspection, the residents of HSR Layout were found extremely alarmed as recent information and statistics reveal a severe pollution crisis in the most major water body in the neighbourhood, Agara Lake. What was once a vital ecological resource, has now become a source of stagnation, creating significant risks towards the public health. It is not only the free flow of untreated sewage waste but also the increasing amount of nitrate levels in the water that make it unusable. The lake, which is currently being developed and remodelled to be a recreational and sports hub, no longer is used as a domestic water source for the local residents. The creation of this hub aims to boost the community activities, but it has unintentionally concealed the rapid decline of ecological levels of the stream. Untreated sewage water keeps pouring into the lake due to insufficient waste management systems. Unregulated solid waste along the lake's edges has further affected the water quality negatively. The recent scientific tests drew a worrying picture. The lake's Biological Oxygen Demand(BOD), has reached a level of 25-35mg/L, which is far above the maximum safety requirement of 3mg/L. Such elevated BOD suggests increasing organic pollution, most likely caused by sewage and decaying waste. The Chemical Oxygen Demand(COD), has exceeded the maximum limit of 200mg/L. This points to the presence of industrial waste, detergents, and chemical residue. In addition to all these, the fecal coliform counts have spiked to 10,000MPN/100ml, confirming the presence of disease-causing bacteria. These statistics clearly state that Agara Lake is currently unfit for human use. Although it's been seen that the lake water is not used for human consumption, it

has indirect and dire consequences to the human well-being. According to a biologist “The lake water can also infiltrate ground water and have appalling consequences”. Over time, the groundwater sources which are used by households i.e, through borewells or local water suppliers can become contaminated with the same pollutants. Another major concern for the lake is the increased nitrate levels in the water. Nitrates in drinking water are known to cause blue baby syndrome, a condition that affects the hemoglobin of infants, reducing their ability to carry oxygen. Long-term exposure to nitrates and heavy metals can also cause cancer, liver and kidney damage, neurological disorders, and complications related to fertility and thyroid function. Biologists agree that nitrate contamination is extremely strenuous to remove. The common purification methods used in households, such as boiling, are proven to be of no use to clear out nitrate . When nitrate treated water is boiled, instead of purifying the compound, it leaves an even higher concentration of nitrate behind. This in turn gets absorbed in the ground water, and the residents unknowingly use it, which can be a major health hazard. Strong concerns over the lake's degradation have been expressed by local environmental specialists and analysts . “The pollution levels at Agara Lake are not just indicators of poor ecological health, they directly threaten public well-being,” said an environmental analyst associated with a local conservation group. “Unless sewage inflow is immediately diverted and a comprehensive restoration plan is put in place, the damage may soon become irreversible.” Experts suggest that to rehabilitate the lake and its adjacent area, improving the sewage inflow and betterment in waste management would be helpful. Residents of HSR Layout are increasingly vocal about the crisis, urging authorities to take urgent corrective action. Many locals have reported changes in the taste and smell of the water they receive at home. Parents, in particular, are worried about the long-term effects on children. “We are using this water every day without knowing what it contains. It's frightening to think that boiling or filtering may not be enough,” said a concerned resident. Community groups have started organizing awareness campaigns to inform the public and pressurize local bodies to intervene. The crisis at Agara Lake serves as a stark reminder of the consequences of neglecting urban water bodies. As Bengaluru continues to expand, water security and quality remain crucial issues that affect thousands of families. The deteriorating condition of the lake highlights the urgent need for better urban planning, effective waste management, and swift governmental response. Until meaningful restoration efforts begin, the health and safety of HSR Layout's residents will remain at risk, making this a crisis that cannot be ignored.

Report 3

The busy streets of KR Market during dusk In the early hours of the morning, when most of Bengaluru is asleep, the fruit vendors are already standing in KR Market with their hands buried in piles of different fruits. The air is thick with the smell of fresh fruit. The market wakes up in waves, the wholesalers shouting prices to the vendors quietly preparing for another uncertain day. Viji(47F), a fruit vendor in the KR Market, says softly while stacking the fruits one by one, “People think we just sit and sell fruits, but it is much tougher. Talking to people and taking their attitude is not easy.” But the real difficulty, she admits, is no longer the heat, the bargaining, or even the long hours. It is the sudden stillness. The quiet patches where people used to gather around her stall, chatting, comparing prices, and smelling the fruits. “Now they don't even stop,”

she says. "Their eyes are in their phones." Viji migrated to Karnataka from Tamil Nadu years ago, carrying with her a hope that her children would get the life she couldn't have. With no formal education of her own, she learned to survive through instinct and courage. Every rupee she earns from kiwi, mango, and pear sales is tied to her family's survival. "We support our whole family with this," she continues. "If business goes down more, I don't know what will happen." Across the street, in a narrow aisle, past crates stacked with pomegranates, sits Rizwan Khan(35M). He is younger than Viji, but carries the same tiredness in his shoulders. The tiredness that comes from doing honest work in a world that has suddenly changed its rules. Rizwan mainly sells pomegranates. Every morning, he travels to the wholesale market in Electronic City, returning with crates he arranges carefully. "I'm trying my best to teach my kids," he says, half-smiling, though the worry in his eyes lingered. "We didn't get an education, but we want to give it to our children. Why must they face what we did?" But giving education requires earning, and earning now feels like chasing an unstoppable target. "Since Blinkit and Zepto came," he says. "People don't pay attention to us. They say the delivery will come in ten minutes. How can we fight with our customers?" For Lakshmi Rao(62F), buying fruits is not something she can imagine doing through a phone screen. Every morning, she stops at the same stretch of vendors and buys whatever is fresh that day. "I come here daily. Not because I don't know about the apps, but because this is how I have always lived," he says. Watching customers drift away to online platforms worries him. "These people fed the city when there were no supermarkets, no delivery boys. But now people only crave convenience," he said tragically. The picture where her eyes speaks louder than anything else To an outsider, a fruit stall looks simple. But the work begins long before dawn, long before the first customer sees the bright, neatly stacked arrangement. For decades, vendors like Viji and Rizwan were part of Bengaluru's morning rhythm. Their stalls were the original fresh-delivery systems. They fed the office-goers rushing to Majestic, school children returning home, and college friends exploring the streets. Today, they feel themselves fading. The rise of online grocery apps has changed more than how people buy fruit. It has changed who we see. Where once the vendor's voice competed with traffic, now it competes with app notifications. Where once customers stopped to ask, "How much today, akka?", they now scroll up, tap, and wait for a delivery rider whose name they won't even remember tomorrow. For Viji and Rizwan, this shift is more than economic. It is emotional. A slow erasure from the city they helped sustain. Rizwan said it plainly, "People want everything fast. They don't see us anymore. Only the phone." Fruit vendors were never just sellers. They were storytellers, listeners, and everyday anchors. A regular customer could walk up to Viji, and she would already be picking out what they needed, not because of technology, but because of memory, relationship, and trust. Now the apps claim to know your preferences. But they do not know your name. That intimacy, that slow, human connection, is disappearing. And with it, the livelihood of thousands. The most intriguing part of KR Market is not the chaos. It is the sheer passion and determination of the people working there. Despite shrinking income, Viji still arrives before dawn. Despite long hours, Rizwan still arranges his pomegranates with pride. They speak of struggle, but they do not speak of quitting. Quitting for them has never been an option. Their work is not just about fruits. It is about identities and the struggles of these people who were the very backbone of the informal sector of economy. It is a very simple truth that when vendors like Viji and Rizwan disappear, Bengaluru loses more than a cheap source of fruits. It loses history. It loses community. It loses humanity. For now, they remain small islands

of color and resilience in a city speeding past them. But they hope the city pauses long enough to remember that behind every fruit is a human story. Behind every stall is a family trying to live. And behind the convenience of a 10-minute delivery is someone who is slowly losing the only livelihood they have ever known.